

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Managing Priorities & Energy

Company → Team → Self (Baseline Alignment)

- ☐ Before making a decision, ask: *Does this serve the company first?*
- ☐ Next ask: *Does this strengthen the team?*
- ☐ Then ask: *Where do my personal preferences fit?*
- ☐ Avoid prioritizing individual or team preferences over company priorities.
- ☐ Re-evaluate if you're following this hierarchy too rigidly.

Balance Impact With Engagement

- ☐ Am I doing work that is impactful?
- ☐ Am I staying personally energized and engaged?
- ☐ If I'm burning out, have I adjusted my work mix?
- ☐ Am I sacrificing long-term sustainability for short-term correctness?

Reminder: A long-term career requires both impact **and** energy.

Energy Management (Positive-Sum Thinking)

- ☐ Do I know what types of work energize me?
- ☐ Does each team member know what energizes them?
- ☐ Have I intentionally included some energizing work in the mix?
- ☐ Am I allowing others to do energizing work (even if not maximally important)?
- ☐ Is energizing work avoiding negative spillover onto other teams?

Strategic Rule-Breaking (With Guardrails)

- ☐ If I'm deviating from strict priorities, is it to restore energy?
- ☐ Is this deviation modest and controlled?
- ☐ Will this create maintenance, execution, or coordination burdens for others?
- ☐ Is this orthogonal (neutral) to company goals — not opposed to them?

OK: Small orthogonal work

Not OK: Work in opposition to the company's needs

Eventual Quid Pro Quo Framework

- ☐ Generally prioritize company and team over personal work.
- ☐ If de-energized, intentionally increase energizing work until balance returns.
- ☐ If imbalance persists for ~1 year, seriously reassess role or environment.
- ☐ Avoid short-term “what’s in it for me?” thinking in leadership roles.
- ☐ Ensure repayment/reward timing is decoupled from immediate effort.

Context Awareness (Mirrors of Misalignment)

- ☐ When something seems misaligned, ask: *What context might I be missing?*
- ☐ Operate from curiosity rather than judgment.
- ☐ Share the strategic context more widely if you're senior.
- ☐ Seek tactical context if you're senior and removed from execution.
- ☐ Recognize that seniority creates knowledge gaps as well as insight.

Orthogonal, Not Opposed

- ☐ Limit outside or exploratory work to moderate levels.
- ☐ Avoid introducing tools/technologies purely for personal interest.
- ☐ Sanity-check gray-area decisions with a trusted peer.

- ☐ If uncertain whether something is aligned, treat that as a warning sign.

Flexibility Over Rigid Adherence

- ☐ Am I overvaluing “correctness” at the expense of progress?
- ☐ Do I equate lack of adherence with character flaws?
- ☐ Am I building relationships or alienating others through rigidity?
- ☐ Can I mute my desire for strict adherence when progress requires flexibility?

Quick Weekly Reflection

- ☐ What energized me this week?
- ☐ What drained me?
- ☐ Did I prioritize correctly?
- ☐ Did I adapt intelligently?
- ☐ Is my current path sustainable for 12+ months?